



ASTEROIDS AND COMETS

Asteroids are lumps of rock, iron, and nickel, and are much smaller than planets. Many orbit the Sun in the Asteroid Belt between the orbits of Mars and Jupiter. Comets are chunks of ice and dust that grow tails of glowing dust and gas when their orbits take them close to the Sun and they are blasted by its radiation.

◀ STREAK IN THE SKY

Sometimes comets come close enough to Earth to be seen in the night sky, as when Comet McNaught streaked past our planet in 2007.

FACT!

The Sun is made of the lightest elements in the Universe—hydrogen and helium—but despite this the Sun is at least 333,000 times as heavy as planet Earth.

Uranus



◀ THE PLANETS

The four rocky planets—Mercury, Venus, Earth, and Mars—consist of solid rock, some with shallow atmospheres. The gas giants Jupiter and Saturn have small rocky cores surrounded by thick layers of gas. Uranus and Neptune are similar, but they are mostly frozen because they are so far from the hot Sun.

Neptune



METEORITES

The meteorites that land on Earth range from small pebbles to truck-sized or even larger chunks of space rock. Some are mixtures of rock and iron that formed before the Solar System. Others are parts of shattered planets. This one came from the Moon.



DWARF PLANETS

Astronomers have named five rocky objects as dwarf planets: Ceres, Pluto, Haumea, Makemake, and Eris. Although they are smaller than the eight major planets, they are larger than the thousands of other tiny worlds in the Solar System. Pluto has a moon called Charon, which is almost half the size of Pluto—the two orbit each other like twins, as seen in this distant view from Earth.

